Swiss Banking and Digital Assets

The State of Adoption, Bank Strategies and What Comes Next



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00 Foreword

Switzerland offers one of the clearest views into how banks adopt digital assets.

Its institutions entered earlier, and across more types of banks, than in almost any other major financial market. As banks elsewhere now decide how to enter, Swiss institutions can show what happens after launch: which capabilities prove valuable, which operating models endure and what it takes to expand.

The country's head start is visible across the sector:

- Swissquote introduced Bitcoin trading in 2017, followed by private banks, cantonal banks and PostFinance.
- Sygnum and SEBA, now AMINA, received banking licences in 2019 and became regulated infrastructure partners to other institutions.
- Our mapping identifies more than 30 Swiss banks providing some form of cryptocurrency investment access.
- Their approaches range from largely outsourced offerings to hybrid models and internally controlled custody.

Over several months, we spoke with many of the executives and practitioners responsible for digital assets inside these institutions. We asked how their initial decisions were made, what proved harder than expected and how years of operating experience have changed their priorities.

Their answers reveal that Swiss banks did not follow a common playbook. Some entered to retain existing clients. Others sought new wealth, wanted to serve blockchain companies or viewed crypto as a starting point for broader changes in financial infrastructure. Their investment decisions reflect those different objectives.

This report distils those experiences into practical lessons for banks around the world: how to enter digital assets, which capabilities to own, where partnerships add value and how to expand once demand emerges.

It also examines the next test for Switzerland. The country established an early lead in crypto banking. Whether it can translate that experience into a similar position in digital money and tokenized finance remains an open question.

We hope you enjoy it.



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01 Key Insights

01

Switzerland's Early Lead Combined Regulatory Clarity With Real Client Demand

Technology-neutral regulation and direct access to FINMA reduced uncertainty before dedicated DLT legislation existed. That clarity met a competitive banking landscape under pressure to differentiate, plus early demand from blockchain companies, foundations and holders of crypto-generated wealth. Together, these conditions gave Swiss banks reasons to act earlier than peers elsewhere.

02

Switzerland's Lead Is Deep, but Concentrated

More than 30 Swiss banks now provide some form of crypto investment access, yet direct trading and custody remain absent from several major institutions and only five of 24 cantonal banks have launched. Switzerland's lead lies in the depth and variety of experience among early movers, not in market-wide adoption.

03

The First-Mover Opportunity in Crypto Access Has Largely Passed

Early entrants could use crypto to attract clients and assets that other banks would not accept. As major wealth managers globally add access, that window is narrowing. New launches will increasingly protect existing relationships rather than win crypto-native wealth, while differentiation shifts to lending, onchain investment products and broader banking services.

04

Crypto-Generated Wealth Offers Private Banks the Largest Upside

Basic access can meet occasional client demand, but the larger opportunity lies with clients whose wealth already exists onchain. Banks able to verify its origin, accept transfers and connect holdings to liquidity, lending, diversification and investment management can win broader relationships. The addressable market and resulting assets should not be assumed.

05

Swiss Banks Have Adopted Three Distinct Infrastructure Models

The market spans partner-led offerings, hybrid architectures combining internally controlled custody with outsourced execution, and more integrated platforms covering custody and trading. No model is inherently superior. Banks planning broader digital-asset services place greater value on operational control and the flexibility to add transfers, lending or tokenized assets without rebuilding their infrastructure.

06

Europe Is the Next Market for Switzerland's Digital-Asset Specialists

AMINA's Austrian MiCA authorisation and Sygnum's Liechtenstein CASP licence give them regulated access to a larger European market. Medium-sized banks remain natural buyers of integrated platforms, while larger institutions will source more selectively. To preserve their specialist edge, both are expanding beyond trading and custody into tokenized funds, onchain products, blockchain-based payments and institutional banking.

07

Crypto Funds Today's Capabilities While Tokenization Stays the Long-Term Bet

Trading and custody already answer visible client demand, giving banks a reason to fund infrastructure, controls and blockchain expertise today. Those capabilities can later support tokenized securities, collateral and settlement, but they do not guarantee adoption. Swiss banks will only increase their investment meaningfully once tokenization demonstrates clear operational gains and enough assets and counterparties participate to deliver them at scale.

08

The Swiss Franc Still Lacks a Stablecoin With Domestic Scale

The franc's appeal as a store of value has not produced enough transaction demand to cover the operating costs of a Swiss issuer, while low interest rates weaken reserve economics. The joint CHF stablecoin sandbox is therefore testing whether programmable payments can create repeatable use cases across banking and onchain markets.

MARKET OVERVIEW

Who Offers What

Selected direct crypto services and digital-money initiatives at Switzerland's 15 largest banking institutions by 2025 total assets, as of September 2026

● LIVE ○ IN PREPARATION / PILOT — NO PUBLIC OFFERING IDENTIFIED

BANK	CUSTODY	DIRECT TRADING	CRYPTO LOANS	STAKING	STABLECOIN
UBS	—	—	● BITCOIN ETF AS COLLATERAL	—	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX ○ G7-CURRENCY CONSORTIUM
RAIFFEISEN	○ ANNOUNCED (SYGNUM)	○ ANNOUNCED (SYGNUM)	—	—	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX
Zürcher Kantonalbank	● FIREBLOCKS	● CRYPTO FINANCE	—	—	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX
PostFinance	● SYGNUM	● SYGNUM	—	● SYGNUM	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX ● USDC
Julius Bär	● AMINA	● AMINA	● DIRECT CRYPTO	—	—
MIGROS BANK	—	—	—	—	—
Luzerner Kantonalbank	● FIREBLOCKS	● WYDEN	● DIRECT CRYPTO	—	● USDC + USDT
BCV	—	—	—	—	○ CHF STABLECOIN SANDBOX
Basler Kantonalbank	—	—	—	—	—
St.Galler Kantonalbank	● AMINA	● AMINA	—	—	—
UBP	—	—	—	—	—
BEKB | BCBE	—	—	—	—	—
PICTET 1805	○ IN PREPARATION	○ IN PREPARATION	—	—	—
Aargauische Kantonalbank	—	—	—	—	—
EFG	—	—	—	—	—

ADOPTION FRAMEWORK

How The Different Segments Are Building In Digital Assets

Priorities vary, and there's no single path to adoption. Below is a high-level framework of where activity can be observed in the Swiss market.



This framework covers a curated selection of Swiss banks with active or publicly documented digital-asset initiatives and is not intended as an exhaustive market overview. Positions reflect our qualitative assessment of live crypto-service breadth and demonstrated deployment of tokenization and digital money. Announcements and isolated transactions do not establish recurring commercial adoption. Absence of identified activity does not establish inactivity.

SYGNUM AMINA

How Specialist Banks Are Evolving

IV.
DIGITAL-ASSET BANKS

Banking Switzerland's Emerging Crypto Economy

Switzerland's blockchain ecosystem developed faster than the banking services available to support it. Companies could raise and hold capital in crypto, yet struggle to obtain an account to pay salaries and suppliers. Meanwhile, professional investors wanted access to digital assets through institutions that could combine secure custody with the services and oversight they expected from a bank.

Sygnum and AMINA, originally called SEBA, were established around these needs. Both received Swiss banking licences in August 2019, creating institutions whose core business was connecting digital assets with conventional finance. Their clients included blockchain companies, foundations, entrepreneurs and institutional investors requiring more than an exchange account.

Custody and trading provided a starting point. Fiat accounts, payments, secured lending and investment services made the relationship more useful. As established banks began exploring their own offerings, the capabilities developed for these clients also became a service those banks could buy.

Direct Banking Creates the Foundation for Bank Partnerships

For Sygnum, serving other banks was part of the strategy from the outset. Direct clients came first because their needs already existed; prospective bank partners still had to agree on a strategy and prepare for launch.

Those initial relationships supplied operational experience and credibility. Partnerships then opened a larger distribution channel, allowing customers to access the specialist's services through their existing bank.



> We started with the direct client business, which earned us credibility as a digital-asset specialist. That was the prerequisite for banks to even consider us in a B2B context. Direct clients still account for more than three-quarters of our revenues, but B2B is where we are growing fastest.
>
> **Thomas Eichenberger,** Sygnum

The benefit extends beyond distribution. Partner banks bring volumes that support continued investment in the platform, while greater scale strengthens Sygnum's proposition to larger institutional clients. Direct banking and B2B can therefore reinforce each other.

A second growth avenue is to deepen the role these banks play in clients' everyday financial activity. At AMINA, crypto trading and lending dominated the early business, but demand is increasingly shifting toward recurring banking and payments. Regulated crypto firms, for example, are seeking fiat accounts, virtual IBANs and connections to stablecoin payment rails. That broadens the opportunity beyond banks launching crypto investment products. Exchanges, brokers and other financial platforms also need regulated banking infrastructure behind their own services.

Why the Banking Licence Matters Commercially

This broader demand highlights an important advantage of the specialists' model: their banking licence allows them to combine digital-asset infrastructure with services that non-bank providers cannot offer in the same relationship. A bank launching digital assets can buy custody software or execution services from several sources. Sygnum and AMINA can combine those capabilities with fiat deposits, payments and balance-sheet lending.

For a crypto platform, that can mean obtaining both asset services and the banking infrastructure needed to receive and move customer money. For another bank, it means working with a counterparty already subject to familiar prudential supervision, governance and operational requirements.



> It is reassuring for banks to work with a provider subject to the same regulatory requirements, oversight, governance and risk-management principles as they are. This was particularly true when we launched in 2019, and it is even more relevant today.
>
> **Thomas Eichenberger,** Sygnum

Technology is still a core part of the offering, but neither bank needs to own every component itself. Both combine proprietary capabilities with external technology. AMINA, for example, uses Fireblocks and Taurus alongside its own deep-cold-storage infrastructure. The advantage is therefore less about the technology itself and more about how it is packaged. A client can access custody, trading and banking services through one regulated provider rather than coordinating several separate relationships. That does not remove the need for outsourcing oversight, but it can reduce the number of counterparties and operational handoffs involved.

01

The Next Applications Require Banks to Work Together

As banks can introduce crypto access by connecting their customers to existing markets, creating a new settlement network requires institutions to agree on how money moves between them, which rules apply and how the service connects to their existing operations. The benefit to each participant depends partly on who else joins.

Swiss banks are participating in several joint initiatives to develop these networks together. They range from securities settlement in central bank money to programmable payments using bank deposits and stablecoins:

JOINT INITIATIVES

Building settlement networks together

INITIATIVE	PURPOSE AND PARTICIPANTS	CURRENT STAGE
Project Helvetia	Settle tokenized securities using wholesale central bank digital currency SNB BNS · Aargauische Kantonalbank · BCV · BLKB · Zürcher Kantonalbank · Basler Kantonalbank · Hypothekarbank Lenzburg · RAIFFEISEN · UBS	●●○ PRODUCTION PILOT
Deposit Token Proof of Concept	Use tokenized payment instructions to trigger off-chain fiat transfers, including an escrow-like asset exchange. UBS · PostFinance · SYGNUM	●○○ COMPLETED POC
CHF Stablecoin Sandbox	Test institutional transfers, digital-asset settlement and programmable payments using CHFD. UBS · PostFinance · SYGNUM · Stablecoin AG · RAIFFEISEN · Zürcher Kantonalbank · TWINT · BCV	●○○ SANDBOX TESTING
Project Agorá	Combine tokenized commercial-bank deposits and central-bank reserves for wholesale cross-border payments. UBS · PostFinance · SYGNUM · AMINA · Basler Kantonalbank · BCV · SNB BNS	●●○ PILOT TESTING

The work extends beyond banks. SIX participates in three of these four initiatives, bringing experience from its role as a major provider of Switzerland's exchange, securities settlement and payment infrastructure. Its involvement connects the experiments with systems that banks already use. Internally, SIX has also merged its digital securities depository into SIX SIS, bringing digital and conventional securities services into the same legal entity as a foundation for more integrated post-trade services.

02

A Digital Franc Must Earn Its Place

The franc's appeal as a store of value gives a CHF stablecoin a potential audience among investors internationally. But demand for the currency alone does not provide an issuer with enough revenue to cover operating costs. For CHF issuers, finding the right business model is particularly difficult. The SNB maintained its policy rate at 0% in June 2026, limiting the attractiveness of a business model funded primarily by CHF reserve income. Our assessment is that payments, foreign exchange and complementary banking services become more important to the investment case.

Experience has been mixed, too. Bitcoin Suisse discontinued CryptoFranc in 2024. Germany-based AllUnity has since launched CHFAU alongside its other currency-backed stablecoins, illustrating how a Swiss-franc stablecoin business can emerge outside Switzerland as part of a broader model for onchain foreign exchange and payments. Frankencoin pursues a different model. ZCHF is created against collateral through a decentralized protocol rather than a fiat-reserve issuer's redemption promise, so its economics and risks require separate assessment.

Swiss banks are now exploring yet another route: a jointly developed model that combines potential distribution with shared experimentation. SIX and TWINT joined the sandbox in September, adding securities and payments expertise. The initiative should help establish where a CHF stablecoin can create tangible value before participating institutions commit to a commercial service.



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